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Monthly App Tracker – December 2025

Umetrip app seemingly gains traction in air ticketing

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MAS rose 1.5% y-y and total monthly time spent increased 10.1% y-y in December

Monthly active smartphone (MAS) users in China, which rose 1.5% y-y to 1.28bn in December 2025, have remained stable in recent months. The total monthly time spent (MTS) grew 10.1% y-y in December, accelerating from the 9.2% y-y rise in November.

Alibaba's consumer AI apps continued their rapid ramp-up

The popularity of top four AI chatbots remained unchanged in December vs November. Notably, Doubao (owned by ByteDance) maintained its position as China's most popular chatbot, with 70mn daily active users (DAU) in December – representing 3.0x y-y and 14% m-m growth. This was followed by Quark AI browser [owned by Alibaba (BABA US, Buy)] at 34mn (up 14% y-y and 1% m-m), Deepseek (unlisted) at 29mn (down 2% m-m), and Yuanbao [owned by Tencent (700 HK, Buy)] at 6.5mn (up 33x y-y and 6% m-m) in December.

Meanwhile, Alibaba's (BABA) consumer AI apps continued to register strong traction in December. The DAU of Qwen, BABA's AI chatbot, surged 6.4x y-y and 1.9x m-m to 3.3mn in December after a relaunch in Nov following a rebranding. AQ, an AI healthcare app launched by Ant Group (unlisted), was rebranded to "Ant Afu" on 15 December 2025 after three major upgrades in functions – health companionship, health Q&A and health services. It recorded 1.1x m-m growth in DAU, reaching 3.5mn in December.

Regarding daily time spent per DAU (DTSD), most AI chatbots maintained their upward trends. Quark secured its leading position with 33.3 minutes in DTSD (flat y-y and up 1% m-m) due to the comprehensive services offered that span across search, cloud storage, and online literature. For other chatbots, DTSD largely remained in the 7-12 minute range.

Umetrip app gained strong user traction

Umetrip [owned by TravelSky (696 HK, Not rated)] is a state-owned air ticketing app whose scale is still small, around 21% of Trip.com (TCOM US, Neutral) app's DAU in Dec. It has shown impressive improvement in its user engagement in the recent months since the revamp of its app in July 2025. In July 2025, Umetrip went beyond its original flights tracking services by starting to offer air ticketing service to its users. It distinguishes its service from the OTA leaders by claiming to offer "transparent non-discriminatory pricing for air tickets that are not bundled with other value-added services (e.g., insurance policies), as has been a common practice in the OTA industry. It seems this simplified air ticketing service did resonate with some travelers, in our view – in December, Umetrip's MTS rose 32% y-y, backed by a 21% growth in DAU and a 9% growth in DTSD. In contrast, Qunar (owned by TRIP.com) edged up 2% y-y in the app's MTS, mainly driven by a 3% increase in DTSD. However, TRIP.com's domestic app registered a 2% decline in MTS in December, dragged by a 9% decline in DTSD, offsetting an 8% growth in DAU. Fliggy's (unlisted, owned by BABA) MTS decreased 3%, dragged by a 7% decline in DAU.

Conversion from ecommerce to QC normalized

The user engagements for BABA's and JD's (JD US, Buy) app continued to outperform that of PDD (PDD US, Neutral), which was partly driven by their quick commerce (QC) investments. JD app's MTS increased 38% y-y in December, driven by 21% y-y growth in DAU and 14% y-y growth in DTSD. Taobao app's MTS went up 9% y-y, mainly driven by 8% y-y growth in DAU. However, PDD's MTS growth lagged behind with just 5% growth in December (mainly backed by 4% y-y growth in DAU).

According to QuestMobile, in December, 23% of Taobao's MAU checked out its QC

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channel located within the app, largely on par with the 22% share in November albeit declining from the 37% share in July. In JD app, the same metric stood at 16% of JD's MAU in Dec, on par with November but down from the 29% share in July. The high level in July was likely boosted by the aggressive subsidies, in our view. Since 4Q, competition in China's QC sector has stabilized, likely leading to a normalization of the conversion from the ecommerce to the QC service.

Douyin and Meituan's merchant apps show diverging trends

Meituan (3690 HK, Neutral) and Dianping (unlisted, owned by Meituan) app both softened in December. Notably, the MTS of Meituan app reversed the growth trend, declining 1% y-y, mainly owing to a 7% y-y drop in DAU. The growth rate of Dianping's MTS decelerated to 5% in December from 8% growth in November, backed by 18% DAU growth and an 11% decline in DTSD. On the merchant front, Meituan's two merchant-facing apps, the merchant app for merchants from the restaurant and local service sector and another merchant app dedicated to merchants from the hotel and travel industry each saw a decline of 7% in MTS, primarily due to a respective decline of 7% and 9% in their DTSD.

In contrast, Douyin's merchant-facing app, Laike (owned by ByteDance) maintained solid growth of 18% in MTS in December, mainly driven by 22% DAU growth.

Kanzhun's Boss Zhipin app gained steam in December likely on later CNY

The online recruitment leader, Kanzhun (BZ US, Not rated), saw growing momentum in its app user engagement. The MTS of its recruitment app, Boss Zhipin, accelerated to 18% growth in Dec. vs. 4% from November thanks to a robust 15% growth in DAU, likely driven by later-than-usual Chinese New Year (CNY) (from usually January to February in 2026). Kanzhun's app was the best performer in the recruitment vertical – its two smaller competitors, Zhaopin and 51Job saw their MTS decline by 8% and 10% y-y respectively.

Overview of leading Chinese apps

Much of the traffic flow in December was dominated by apps owned by Tencent, Bytedance (unlisted), Baidu (BIDU US, Buy), and Alibaba. In particular, Tencent's apps took five spots among the Top-20 in terms of monthly active users (MAU), while Bytedance's apps took five spots among the Top-20 in terms of time spent share in December, according to QuestMobile. Tencent's WeChat alone recorded a 19.7% share in terms of time spent by Chinese mobile users, leading the next two apps – Douyin and Douyin Lite (both unlisted, owned by Bytedance) – with 17.3% and 6.3% time-spent share, respectively.

Fig. 1: Top-20 apps in China, by MAU and time spent – December

Top 20 Apps in MAU: MAUs change and penetration

App Name	Rank M-M chg	Penetration	Penetration Y-Y	Penetration M-M
WeChat	-	88.2%	2.1ppt	0.1ppt
Douyin	↑	76.3%	8.5ppt	1.0ppt
Alipay	-	76.0%	1.8ppt	0.6ppt
Taobao	↓	75.4%	0.2ppt	-2.1ppt
Amap	-	69.9%	4.7ppt	-0.7ppt
Pinduoduo	-	56.4%	-0.5ppt	-0.1ppt
Baidu	-	52.4%	-0.2ppt	-0.4ppt
Sogou Keyboard	-	52.2%	3.4ppt	0.2ppt
QQ	↑	48.7%	-1.6ppt	0.1ppt
JD	↓	47.6%	3.8ppt	-3.1ppt
Baidu Maps	-	43.3%	-1.3ppt	-0.3ppt
Meituan	-	40.7%	0.7ppt	0.0ppt
Baidu Keyboard	-	39.1%	-0.6ppt	0.0ppt
Weibo	-	38.4%	0.2ppt	0.7ppt
Kuaishou	-	38.2%	2.0ppt	1.8ppt
QQ Browser	↑	29.6%	-4.9ppt	-0.3ppt
Toutiao	↓	29.5%	1.1ppt	-1.1ppt
Tencent Video	-	26.7%	-4.1ppt	0.4ppt
Douyin Lite	↑	25.1%	3.2ppt	0.5ppt
iQIYI	↓	24.6%	-3.6ppt	-0.5ppt

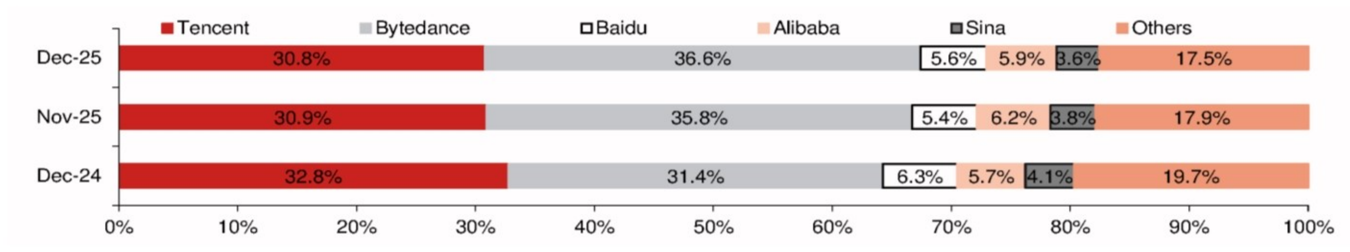
Time spent share for top 20 Chinese mobile apps in December

App Name	Rank M-M chg	Time spent share	Time spent share Y-Y	Time spent share M-M
WeChat	-	19.7%	-0.9ppt	0.0ppt
Douyin	-	17.3%	1.4ppt	0.3ppt
Douyin Lite	-	6.3%	1.2ppt	0.3ppt
Kuaishou	-	4.4%	-0.8ppt	0.0ppt
Sogou Keyboard	-	3.3%	0.0ppt	0.0ppt
Red Fruit Free Short Drama	↑	3.2%	2.0ppt	0.3ppt
Toutiao	↓	3.0%	-0.3ppt	-0.1ppt
Pinduoduo	↑	2.4%	-0.1ppt	0.0ppt
Kuaishou Express	↓	2.4%	-0.4ppt	0.0ppt
Baidu Keyboard	↑	2.3%	0.4ppt	0.2ppt
rednote	↓	2.3%	0.1ppt	0.0ppt
Weibo	↑	2.0%	-0.1ppt	0.0ppt
Fanqie Free Novels	↑	2.0%	0.3ppt	0.0ppt
Taobao	↓	1.9%	0.0ppt	-0.2ppt
Baidu	-	1.7%	-0.5ppt	0.0ppt
Bilibili	-	1.7%	0.0ppt	0.0ppt
Sina News	-	1.4%	-0.3ppt	-0.2ppt
Alipay	-	1.3%	0.2ppt	0.1ppt
Tencent News	↑	1.1%	0.0ppt	0.0ppt
Honour of Kings	↓	1.0%	-0.3ppt	-0.2ppt

Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Among the Top-50 apps, which accounted for ~93% of the total mobile time spent in China during December, we note that the Bytedance camp gained time-spent share on a y-y basis, which rose from 31.4% in December 2024 to 36.6% in December 2025, surpassing Tencent camp's 30.8%. Sequentially, Bytedance's time-spent share was up 0.8pp m-m.

Fig. 2: Time-spent share of various internet camps among the Top-50 apps in China



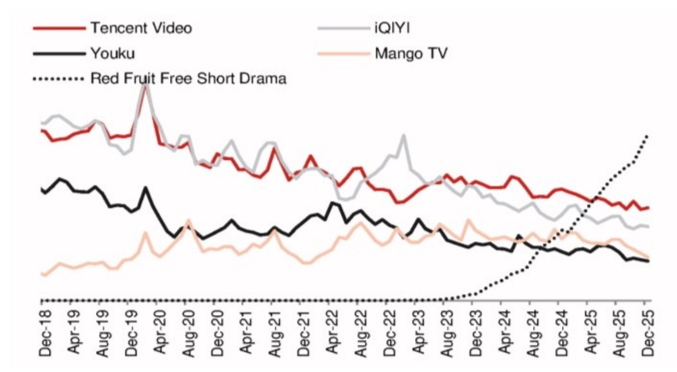
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Long-form vs short-form dramas

Long-form video apps remained weak in December. The MTS of Tencent Video (owned by Tencent) recorded a 22% y-y decline in December, on par with November level, dragged by a 17% decline in DAU and a 6% decline in DTSD. iQIYI (IQ US, Neutral)/ Youku (unlisted, owned by BABA)/Mango TV (300413 CH, Not rated) recorded 15%/30 %/46% y-y decline in total time spent, mainly dragged by 14%/19%/30% declines in DAU.

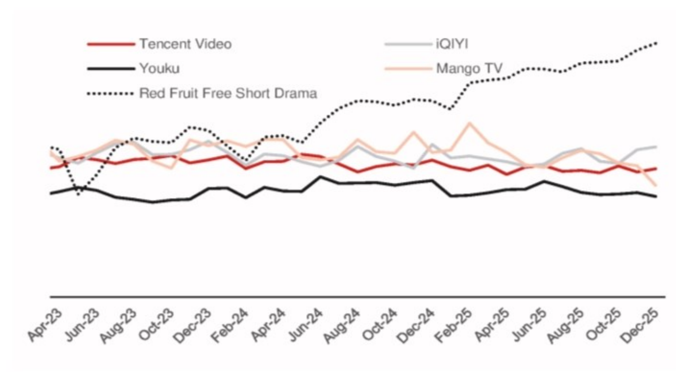
The short-form drama app leader – Red Fruit Free Short Drama – kept its strong growth trend with MTS increase of 204%, backed by 136% growth in DAU and 29% growth in DTSD.

Fig. 3: DAUs of long-form vs short-form dramas apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 4: Average daily time spent per user

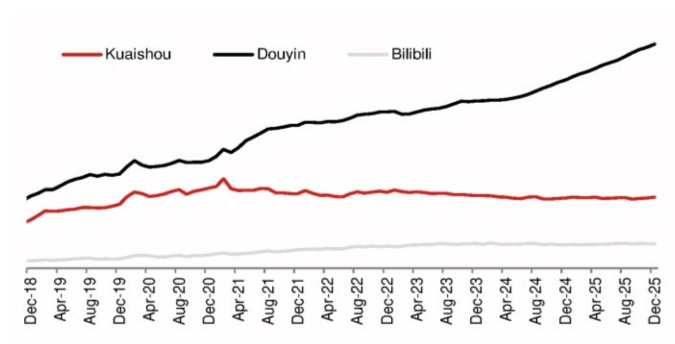


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Short video

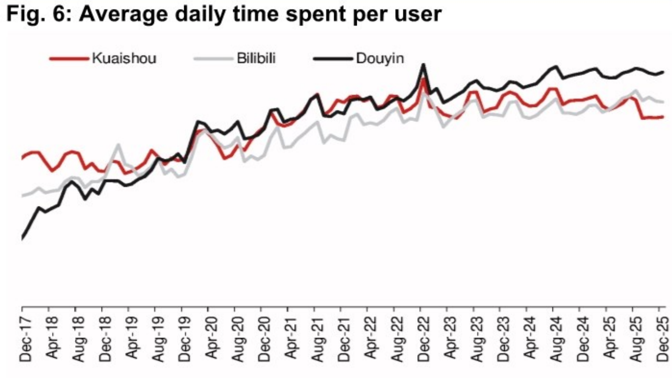
In December, Douyin maintained its solid growth momentum in terms of MTS, at 19% y-y, mainly driven by 19% growth in DAU. Total time spent for Bilibili (BILI US, Neutral) recorded 10% y-y growth in December, driven by 5% y-y growth in DAU and 5% growth in DTSD. However, Kuaishou (1024 HK, Buy) continued its relatively soft performance, with a decline of 7% y-y in MTS, mainly dragged by an 8% y-y decline in DTSD.

Fig. 5: DAUs of short video apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 6: Average daily time spent per user



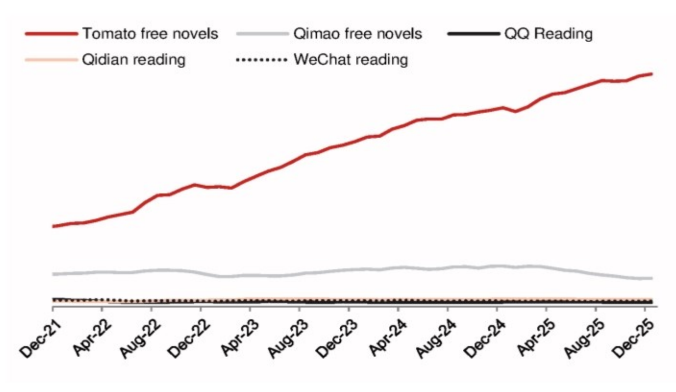
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Online reading

The MTS of the free reading app leader Tomato Free Novels (unlisted; owned by Bytedance) maintained its robust growth momentum, up 28% y-y in December, driven by increases of 17% y-y in DAU and 10% y-y in DTSD. Another free reading app, Qimao Free Novels (unlisted), recorded a 40% y-y decline in total time spent, dragged by respective 30% and 14% y-y declines in DAU and DTSD.

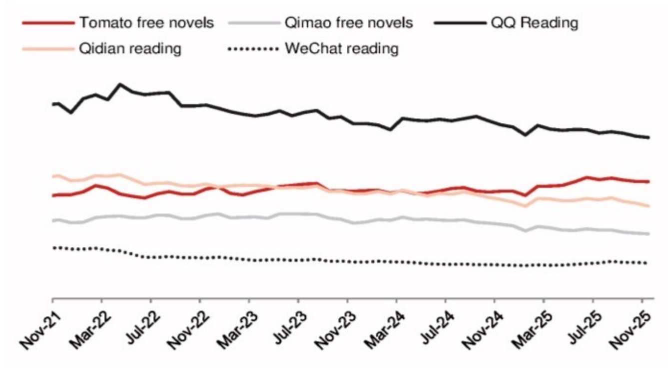
Paid reading apps owned by China Literature (772 HK, Neutral), i.e., Qidian reading and QQ reading, recorded respective 4% and 5% decline on a y-y basis in DAU, during the month, while their DTSD was down by respective 5%% and 7% y-y.

Fig. 7: DAU of online reading platforms



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 8: Average daily time spent per DAU of online reading platforms

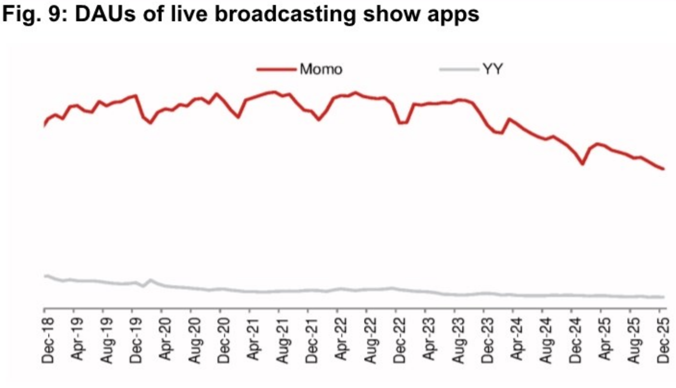


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Live broadcasting

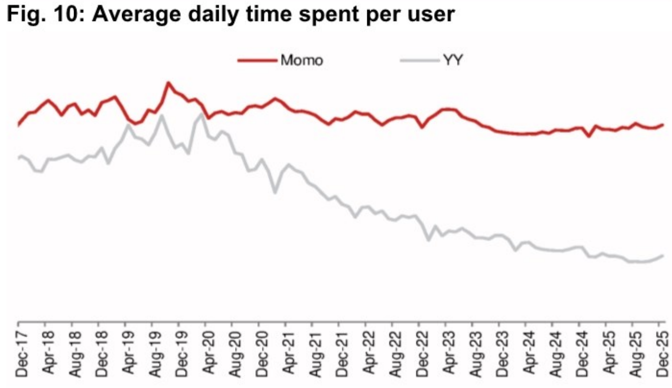
Live broadcasting show apps maintained the y-y downward trend in MTS in December, among which, Momo (MOMO US, Not rated) performed more resiliently than YY (owned by Baidu) in terms of user operational metrics. The DAU of Momo and YY declined by 10% and 13% y-y to 23mn and 2mn, respectively. In terms of DTSD, Momo delivered 2% y-y growth, while YY registered an 11% y-y decline during the month.

Fig. 9: DAUs of live broadcasting show apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

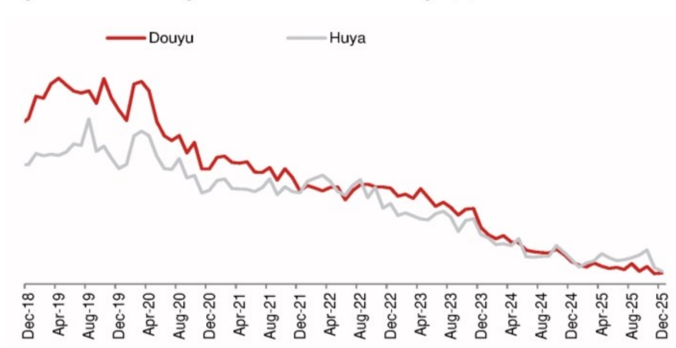
Fig. 10: Average daily time spent per user



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

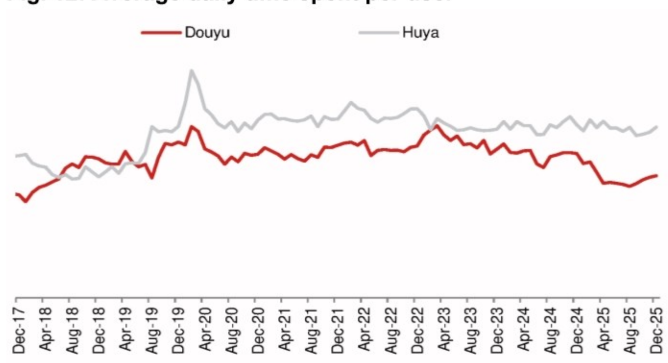
For game live broadcasting apps, the MTS for Huya (HUYA US, Not rated) recorded a 16% decline in December, mainly dragged by a 15% y-y decline in DAU. Douyu (DOYU US, Not rated) maintained its sharp downward trend at -28% y-y in MTS in December, dragged by respective 16% and 15% y-y declines in DAU and DTSD.

Fig. 11: DAUs of game live broadcasting apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 12: Average daily time spent per user



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

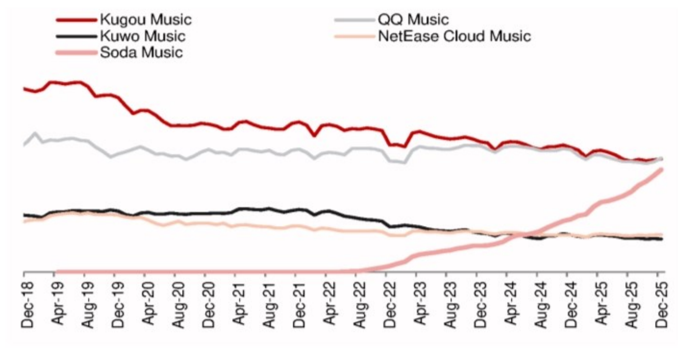
Music

The DAU continued a y-y decline for the most music universe, except for Soda Music (owned by Bytedance), which recorded 94% y-y growth in December. QQ Music / Kugou

Music / Kuwo Music [these three music apps owned by TME (TME US, Buy)] decreased 7%/9%/11%y-y in DAU in December. DAU of NetEase Cloud Music (9899 HK, Not rated) recorded 1% y-y growth in December (as shown in Fig. 13).

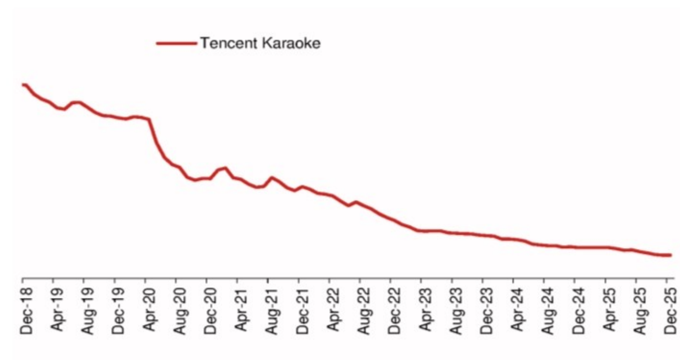
Tencent Karaoke maintained its y-y downward trend in MTS, with a 20% y-y decline, dragged by a 24% drop in DAU in December (as shown in Fig. 14), offsetting a 6% growth in DTSD.

Fig. 13: DAUs of music streaming apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 14: DAUs of online karaoke app

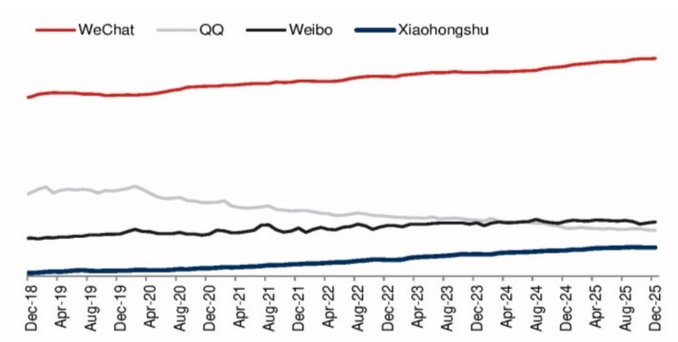


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Social

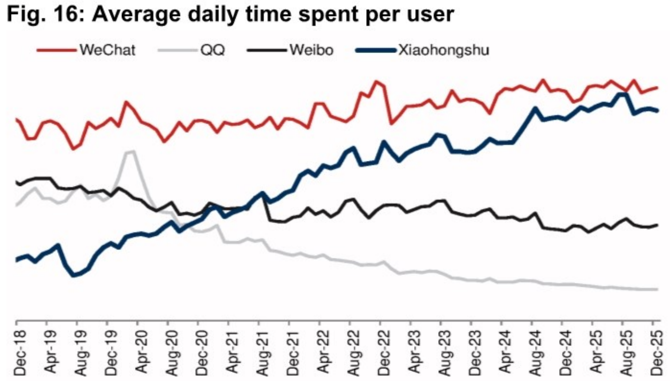
Xiaohongshu (unlisted) maintained strong growth momentum in MTS, at 16% in December, backed by respective 11% and 4% y-y growth in DAU and DTSD. Weibo (WB US, Neutral) recorded 5% y-y growth in MTS in December, backed by a 6% y-y growth in DTSD. Within Tencent's social ecosystem, QQ maintained its downward trend in MTS, with a 17% y-y decline, while WeChat maintained its upward trend in total time spent, with a 5% y-y increase in December.

Fig. 15: DAUs of social apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 16: Average daily time spent per user

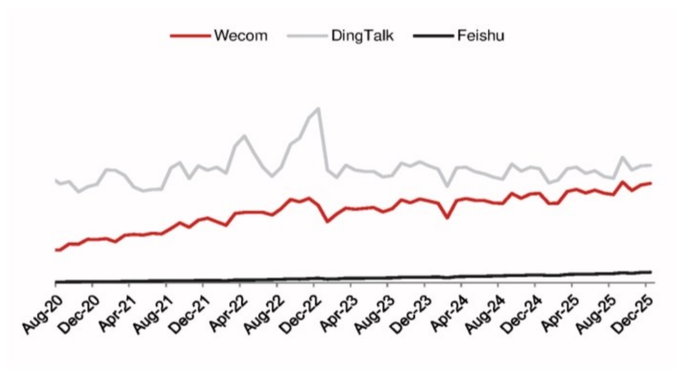


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Office apps

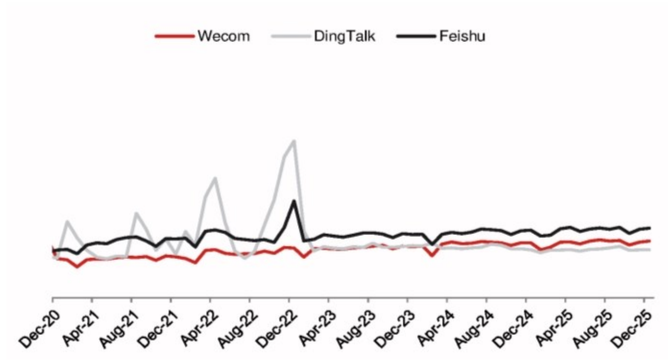
Within the office apps vertical, the DAU of Feishu (owned by Bytedance) recorded the strongest growth of 36% y-y in December, followed by 11% y-y growth for Wecom (owned by Tencent) and 3% growth for Ding Talk (owned by BABA). However, Ding Talk owned the largest DAU base at ~86mn, which was 1.2x and 11.3x that of Wecom and Feishu, respectively. For Feishu, the DTSD was at 14.9 minutes (up 3% y-y), followed by Wecom's 12.1 minutes (up 4% y-y), while DingTalk recorded 10.2 minutes (flat y-y).

Fig. 17: DAUs of office business apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 18: Average daily time spent per user

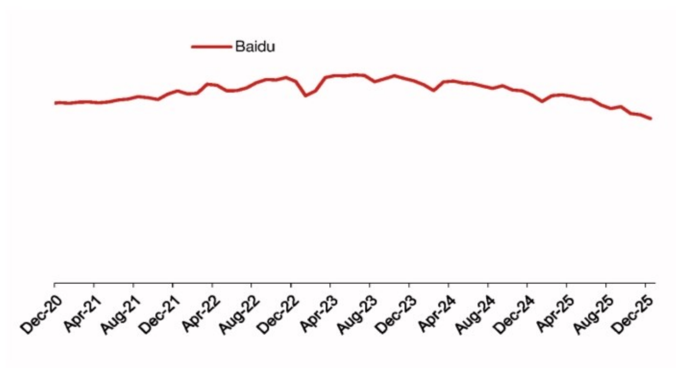


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Search

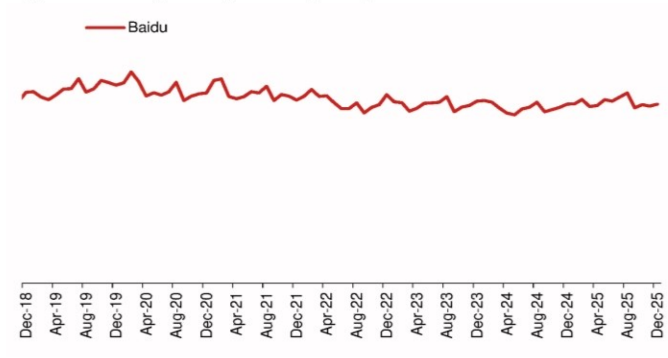
The Baidu app, despite being a dominant search engine in China, witnessed a 12% y-y decline in MTS during the month, dragged by a 12% y-y decline in DAU. The DTSD of Baidu app recorded flat y-y in December.

Fig. 19: DAU of Baidu app



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 20: Average daily time spent per user

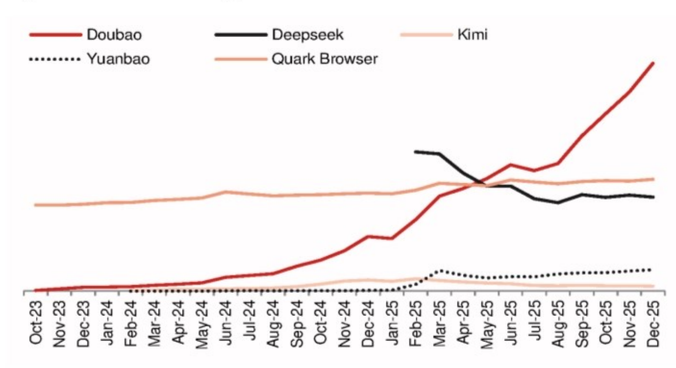


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

AI tools

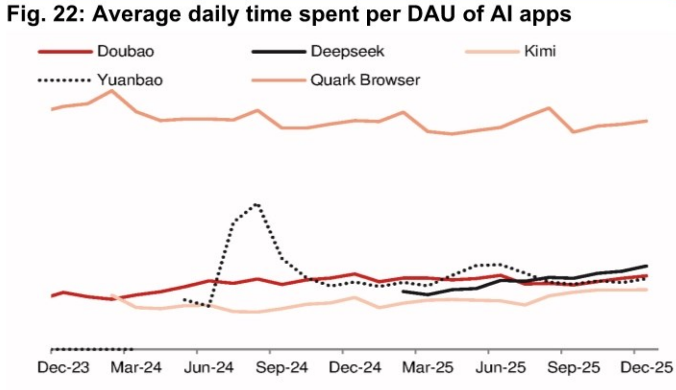
The DAU of Doubao (owned by Bytedance) ranked first in December at 70mn, representing 3.0x y-y and 14% m-m growth. This was followed by Quark AI browser at 34mn (up 14% y-y and 1% m-m), Deepseek at 29mn (down 2% m-m), and Yuanbao at 6.5mn (up 33x y-y and 6% m-m). In terms of DTSD, Quark Browser recorded the highest time spent at 33.3 minutes in December (flat y-y and up 1% m-m). Deepseek ranked the second at 12.2 minutes (up 7% m-m), followed by Doubao's 10.7 minutes (down 2% y-y but up 4% m-m) and Yuanbao's (owned by Tencent) 10.3 minutes (up 5% y-y and 6% m-m).

Fig. 21: DAUs of AI apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 22: Average daily time spent per DAU of AI apps

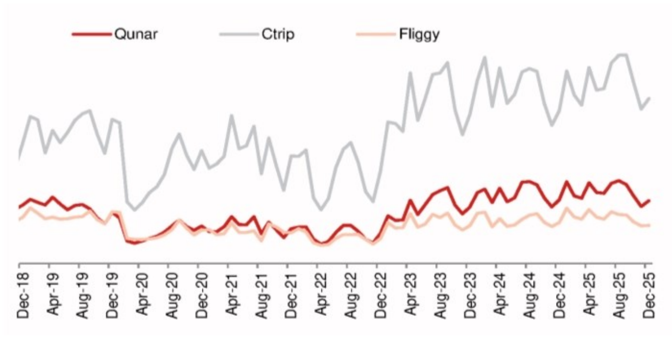


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Online travel

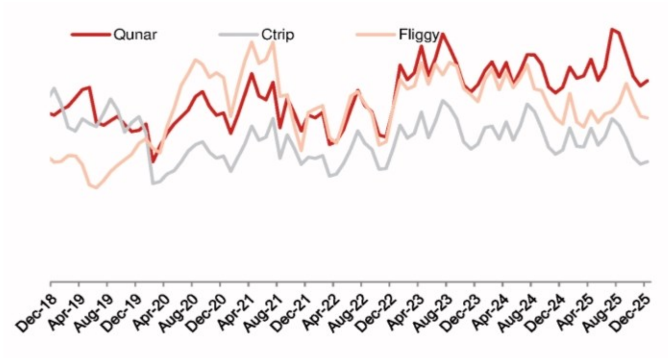
Among online travel apps, Qunar [owned by TRIP.com (TCOM US, Neutral)] recorded 2% y-y growth in MTS in December, driven by a 3% increase in DTSD, offsetting a 1% decline in DAU. However, TRIP.com's domestic app registered a 2% decline in MTS in December, dragged by a 9% decline in DTSD, offsetting 8% growth in DAU. Fliggy (unlisted, owned by BABA) decreased 3% in MTS, dragged by a 7% decline in DAU, offsetting 4% growth in DTSD.

Fig. 23: DAUs of online travel apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 24: Average daily time spent per user



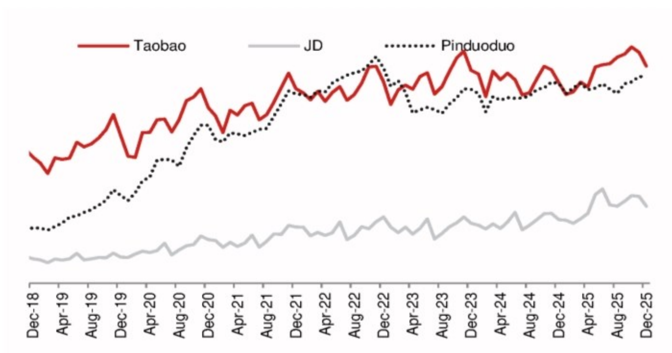
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

E-commerce

Alibaba's Taobao app and Pinduoduo app were the top-two e-commerce names in terms of users and total time spent. In December, Taobao's DAU grew 8% y-y, driven by a 9% growth in the number of hardcore users (daily time spent >1 minute) and 4% growth in the number of casual user (daily time spent < 1 minute). Pinduoduo's DAU rose 4% y-y, driven by a 32% rise in casual user number. JD app's DAU increased 21% y-y, driven by a 20% y-y growth in the number of hardcore users and a 22% y-y growth in the number of casual users.

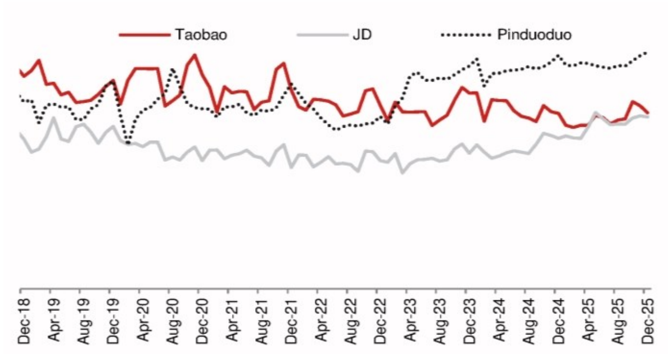
In terms of DTSD, JD delivered the fastest growth at 14% y-y in December. PDD and Taobao registered respective 1% y-y and flat growth in December.

Fig. 25: DAUs of China e-commerce apps



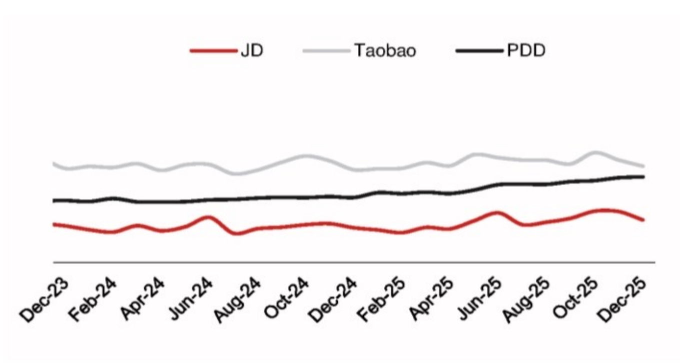
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 26: Average daily time spent per user



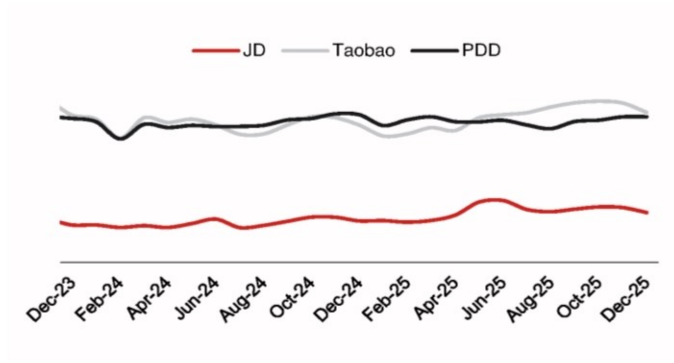
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 27: Number of users with daily time spent at <1 minute



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 28: Number of users with daily time spent at >1 minute

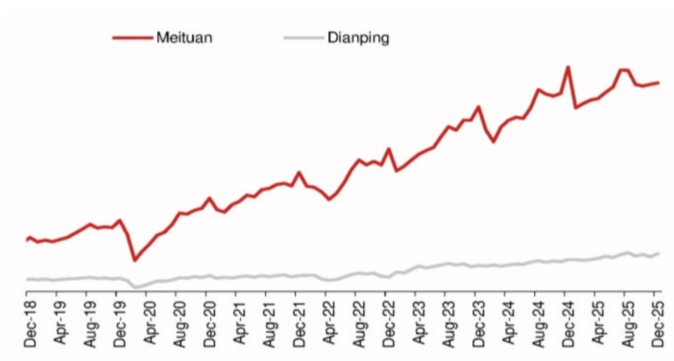


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

O2O

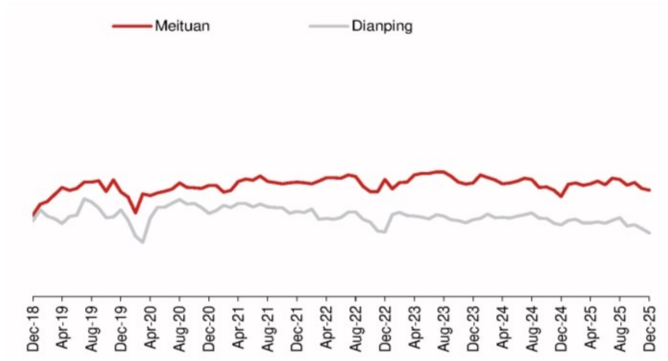
Meituan app recorded 1% y-y decline in MTS in December, dragged by a 7% decline in DAU, offsetting 6% growth in DTSD. Dianping app (owned by Meituan) recorded 5% growth in MTS, driven by 18% y-y growth in DAU, partially offset by an 11% decline in DTSD.

Fig. 29: DAUs of Meituan and Dianping



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 30: Average daily time spent per user

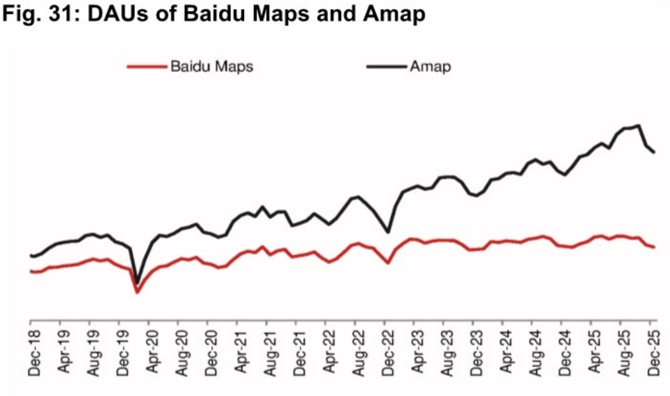


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Mobile map apps

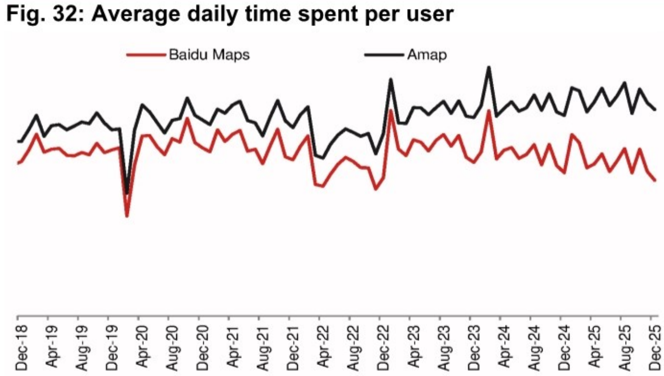
In terms of total monthly time spent, Amap (owned by BABA) recorded 19% growth, mainly driven by 16% growth in DAU. However, total time spent on Baidu Maps (owned by Baidu) recorded a 6% y-y decline in December, mainly dragged by a 5% drop in DTSD.

Fig. 31: DAUs of Baidu Maps and Amap



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 32: Average daily time spent per user



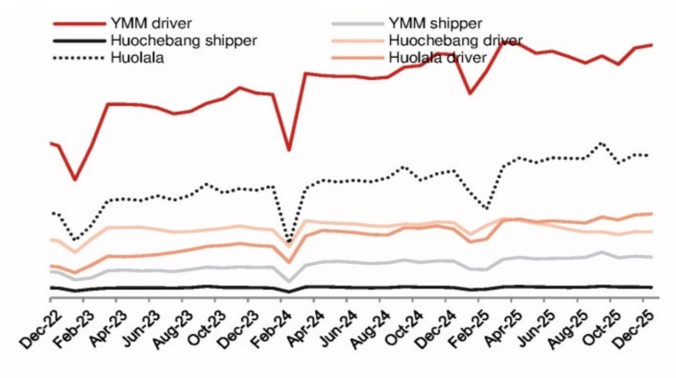
Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Digital freight apps

On the shipper side, the MTS growth of YMM shipper/Huochebang shipper (both owned by Full Truck Alliance, FTA [YMM US, Not rated])/Huolala (unlisted) recorded 12%/4%/11% y-y in December, which was mainly driven by 11%/1%/12% growth in DAU.

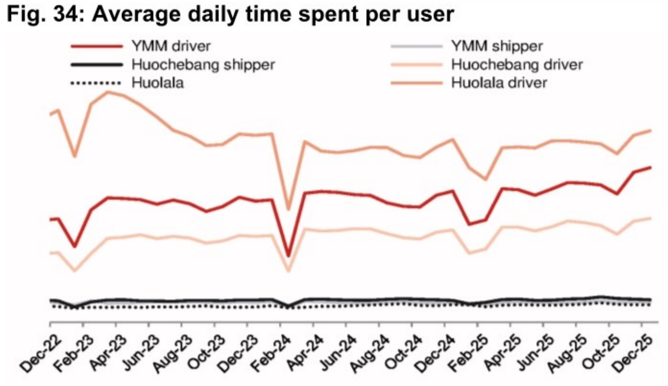
On the driver side, YMM driver (owned by FTA) recorded 22% growth in MTS in December, mainly driven by 18% growth of DTSD; Huolala driver (unlisted) registered 28% growth in MTS, mainly supported by 22% growth of DAU. However, the MTS of Huochebang driver (owned by FTA) declined 1% y-y in December, mainly dragged by a 12% drop of DAU.

Fig. 33: DAUs of digital freight apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 34: Average daily time spent per user

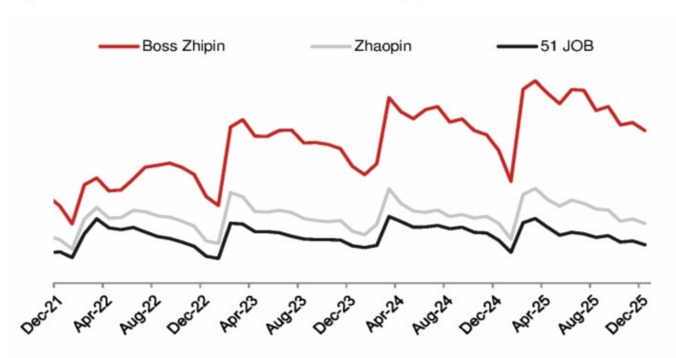


Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Online recruitment apps

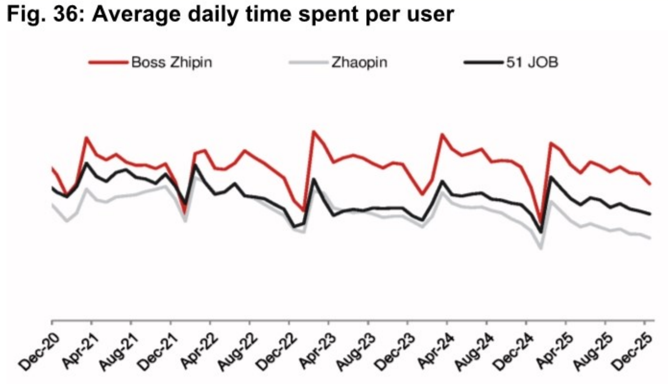
Boss Zhipin app [owned by Kanzhun (BZ US, Not rated)], a leading player in the online recruitment industry, recorded 18% y-y growth in MTS in December, accelerating from 4% y-y growth in November, mainly driven by 15% y-y growth in DAU. However, the MTS of Zhaopin (unlisted) decreased 8% y-y in December, narrowing from the 15% decline in November, dragged by an 8% decline in DTSD. Another peer, 51Job (unlisted), reported a 10% y-y decline in MTS in December (vs down 20% in November), dragged by a 10% drop in DAU.

Fig. 35: DAUs of online recruitment apps



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

Fig. 36: Average daily time spent per user



Source: QuestMobile, Nomura research

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